

Nielsen Norman Group **Heuristic Evaluation Workbook**

Use this workbook to conduct your own heuristic evaluation.

For each of Jakob's 10 Usability Heuristics, look for specific places where the interface fails to adhere to the guideline. Write your recommendations for how to fix those usability issues.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

EVALUATOR:

DATE:

PRODUCT:

TASK:

1

Visibility of System Status

The design should always keep users informed about what is going on, through appropriate feedback within a reasonable amount of time.

- Does the design clearly communicate its state?
- Is feedback presented quickly after user actions?

Issues

The system does not immediately show loading indicators after clicking buttons or submitting forms. Users may become unsure if the action was processed successfully.

Recommendations

Add loading animations, progress indicators, and confirmation messages after every important user action to provide immediate feedback.

2

Match Between System and the Real World

The design should speak the users' language. Use words, phrases, and concepts familiar to the user, rather than internal jargon. Follow real-world conventions, making information appear in a natural and logical order.

- Will user be familiar with the terminology used in the design?
- Do the design's controls follow real-world conventions?

Issues

Some labels and terms are too technical and may not be familiar to users. Certain icons are unclear and do not reflect real-world meanings.

Recommendations

Use simple and familiar language, replace technical terms with user-friendly words, and use recognizable icons that match real-world expectations.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

3

User Control and Freedom

Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave the unwanted action without having to go through an extended process.

- Does the design allow users to go back a step in the process?
- Are exit links easily discoverable?
- Can users easily cancel an action?
- Is *Undo* and *Redo* supported?

Issues

Users cannot easily cancel actions or go back to the previous page during certain processes. Some forms do not provide a reset or undo option.

Recommendations

Add clear back, cancel, undo, and reset buttons so users can recover easily from mistakes or unwanted actions.

4

Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. Follow platform and industry conventions.

- Does the design follow industry conventions?
- Are visual treatments used consistently throughout the design?

Issues

Fonts, button styles, colors, and layouts are inconsistent across different pages. Similar actions sometimes use different labels.

Recommendations

Maintain consistent design elements, button placements, colors, and terminology throughout the system to improve familiarity and usability.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

5

Error Prevention

Good error messages are important, but the best designs carefully prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Either eliminate error-prone conditions, or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.

- Does the design prevent slips by using helpful constraints?
- Does the design warn users before they perform risky actions?

Issues

The system allows incomplete or invalid inputs without warning users before submission. Users can accidentally perform actions without confirmation.

Recommendations

Add input validation, confirmation dialogs, required field indicators, and restrictions to prevent user errors before they occur.

6

Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimize the user's memory load by making elements, actions, and options visible. The user should not have to remember information from one part of the interface to another. Information required to use the design (e.g. field labels or menu items) should be visible or easily retrievable when needed.

- Does the design keep important information visible, so that users do not have to memorize it?
- Does the design offer help in-context?

Issues

Important information such as instructions and labels are hidden or difficult to locate. Users must remember previous steps to continue tasks.

Recommendations

Keep instructions, labels, and navigation visible and accessible at all times to reduce users' memory load.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

7

Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Shortcuts — hidden from novice users — may speed up the interaction for the expert user such that the design can cater to both inexperienced and experienced users. Allow users to tailor frequent actions.

- Does the design provide accelerators like keyboard shortcuts and touch gestures?
- Is content and functionality personalized or customized for individual users?

Issues

The system lacks shortcuts and quick-access features for experienced users. Repetitive tasks require too many steps.

Recommendations

Add shortcuts, autofill options, search features, and customizable settings to improve efficiency for both new and experienced users.

8

Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Interfaces should not contain information that is irrelevant or rarely needed. Every extra unit of information in an interface competes with the relevant units of information and diminishes their relative visibility.

- Is the visual design and content focused on the essentials?
- Have all distracting, unnecessary elements been removed?

Issues

Some pages contain excessive text, crowded layouts, and unnecessary visual elements that distract users from important content.

Recommendations

Simplify the interface by removing unnecessary elements, improving spacing, and focusing only on relevant information and features.

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9

Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no error codes), precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.

- Does the design use traditional error message visuals, like bold, red text?
- Does the design offer a solution that solves the error immediately?

Issues

Error messages are unclear, technical, or do not explain how users can solve the issue. Some errors are not visually noticeable.

Recommendations

Use simple and specific error messages with clear instructions and visual indicators that guide users toward resolving the problem.

10

Help and Documentation

It's best if the system doesn't need any additional explanation. However, it may be necessary to provide documentation to help users understand how to complete their tasks.

- Is help documentation easy to search?
- Is help provided in context right at the moment when the user requires it?

Issues

The system does not provide enough help guides, FAQs, or tutorials for users who need assistance.

Recommendations

Add accessible help documentation, tooltips, FAQs, and user guides that users can easily search and understand.